

This once-depressed region pulled off an industrial revival. Can Europe clone it?

送信者: POLITICO Pro Article 受信日時: 2026-07-14 13:27

【要点】

- ・フランスのダンケルク市は衰退した鋼鉄産業から電池工場などのクリーンテック産業への転換に成功し、失業率を11.9%から8.6%に低下させた産業復興のモデルケースである。
- ・欧州委員会はダンケルク方式を欧州全域に複製するため、許可手続き迅速化と公共機関の協調を促進する産業加速化法案の制定を検討している。
- ・しかし、ダンケルク復興の成功には原子力発電の豊富さ、深海港、既存の産業労働力、10年以上の政治的コミットメントなど、法律では実現できない構造的利点が不可欠であった。
- ・深水港や政治的ビジョンといった競争上の優位性は内陸部では再現不可能であり、地方自治体とビジネスの長期的な協調体制は法令では創出できない。

【メール原文】

DUNKIRK, France — Dunkirk is exactly the kind of industrial success story Brussels wants to replicate across Europe: a declining steel town reinvented

Pro is better in the app.

[Click here to download.](#)

This once-depressed region pulled off an industrial revival. Can Europe clone it?

By Aude van den Hove · Jul 14, 2026, 6:26 AM · [View in your browser](#)

DUNKIRK, France — Dunkirk is exactly the kind of industrial success story Brussels wants to replicate across Europe: a declining steel town reinvented through battery gigafactories, green industry and billions of euros in private investment.

The trouble is that much of what made it work can't simply be legislated in Brussels.

The European Commission hopes to recreate the Dunkirk recipe across Europe through its proposed Industrial Accelerator Act , the centerpiece of Ursula von der Leyen's second-term economic agenda. The bill would require governments to designate "industrial acceleration areas " offering faster permitting, upgraded infrastructure and closer coordination among public authorities to attract manufacturers.

But Dunkirk's recovery also depended on structural advantages that many regions simply don't have: abundant nuclear power, a deep-water port, an existing industrial workforce and more than a decade of political commitment.

"Our industrial strategy is based on the green transition and industrial decarbonization," Mayor Patrice Vergriete told POLITICO in an interview. Rather than "court 20th-century industries," he said, Dunkirk had deliberately set out to attract battery makers and other clean-tech manufacturers.

After its near-total destruction in World War II, the port city on the northern French coast became one of Europe's major steelmaking centers. But the collapse of the industry in the 1980s, followed by the 2008 financial crisis, left it searching for a new economic future.

Vergriete, a left-leaning politician who won office in 2014, vowed to bring about an industrial renaissance by building on the region's strengths.

The unemployment rate has dropped on his watch from 11.9 percent in 2013 to 8.6 percent in 2025 , slightly above the national average. The municipality is also betting that new industrial projects will directly create 20,000 jobs by 2030, and another 10,000 indirectly.

Offering a complete regional policy package — from free buses to good schools — has been crucial to Dunkirk's recovery, said Rafaël Ponce, general director of public-private development agency EcosystèmeD: "The territory's attractiveness is essential," he explained, saying it had drawn in industrial investors, suppliers and workers.

What Brussels can't copy

Many of the competitive advantages that helped Dunkirk thrive lie beyond the reach of industrial policy, however. Deep-water ports cannot be conjured inland, and the political vision that aligned local authorities and businesses over more than a decade can't be summoned by decree.

That, in a nutshell, is the central challenge for the Commission's Industrial Accelerator Act.

While the proposal would require that every EU country designate at least one industrial acceleration area, Brussels would play only a supporting role — helping governments identify suitable sites and coordinating cross-border projects.

Most of the work would fall to national governments, which would decide where to locate the areas, what industries to prioritize and how many zones to create.

Coordination will be crucial "to avoid cannibalization effects," said André Wolf, a researcher at the Centre for European Policy in Berlin, warning that competing national strategies could undermine both existing industrial clusters and planned investments.

Wolf argued that governments should be required to share information about their industrial cluster strategies and report regularly to Brussels, much as they already do under EU energy and climate policy. But those mechanisms are missing from the Commission's proposal, he said.

"This is not about concentrating support in a few regions," Commission spokesperson Siobhan McGarry said in written comments to POLITICO. "The aim is to ensure every member state creates at least one location where industrial projects can be developed more quickly and predictably."

Winning investors

Preparing industrial sites is only half the battle. Governments must also persuade companies that those locations are worth billions of euros in long-term investment.

Dunkirk shows how that can happen. Despite operating steel plants across Europe, ArcelorMittal chose the French port — where it has been present for 60 years — as one of the main sites for its

decarbonization strategy. It announced a €1.3 billion investment earlier this year to convert its plant to a greener electric model.

Bruno Ribo, head of ArcelorMittal France, told POLITICO the decision was driven primarily by access to industrial land, transport links and cheap low-carbon electricity. But the city's industrial heritage mattered too, with its skilled workforce and a supplier base that would be difficult to reproduce elsewhere.

"You have access to the port, to the railway and to electricity. Everything is here," Ribo said. "This is also the reason why new industries, like those producing batteries, come here and not elsewhere."

ArcelorMittal has signed an 18-year contract with Electricité de France to power its electric arc furnace, which will multiply the power consumption of its steelworks by a factor of three.

For Vergriete, those structural advantages only became meaningful after the city built a coherent strategy around them. The arrival of French battery maker Verkor in 2022, he said, was a "grand victory." The six-year-old startup, backed by €3 billion in public and private investment, opened its first battery cell gigafactory in Dunkirk last December.

The industrial revival is reshaping Dunkirk itself: New developments are rising to house incoming workers and their families, while the waterfront has been reimaged to make their leisure time more enjoyable.

One model, many realities

The Industrial Accelerator Act assumes that every member state can create its own Dunkirk. Whether that's realistic is another matter.

Not many countries have France's historical approach to industrial policy, said Philipp Lausberg, a senior policy analyst at the European Policy Centre in Brussels.

"This sort of dirigiste tradition in French economic policy clearly plays a role here," he said, highlighting France's centralized power structure and development institutions as drivers of its active industrial policy.

The deeper challenge, Wolf argued, is that successful industrial regions can't be created simply by preparing land or offering subsidies. They depend on broader industrial ecosystems — networks of suppliers, skilled workers and research institutions — that often take decades to develop.

That risks widening Europe's existing regional disparities, as countries with stronger ecosystems may be better placed to exploit the new rules.

The EU has seen this dynamic before. When Brussels temporarily loosened state aid rules during the 2022 energy crisis, the largest share of approved subsidies were issued in Germany and France, raising fears that richer member states were pulling further ahead.

Dunkirk's revival predates Brussels' latest industrial push. Asked whether Europe can copy it, the city's mayor was doubtful. On one hand, Vergriete said, "it cannot be replicated because there are local specificities," although perhaps the principles behind Dunkirk's revival might be applied elsewhere.

But what's important is that the EU is trying to raise its industrial game to compete better with China, he reflected: "Europe is coming in today, and it's indispensable for Dunkirk."

Competition and Industrial Policy Sustainability Energy and Climate Mobility Trade

Batteries Buildings Buses Companies Courts Crisis Decarbonization Development Electricity Energy
Energy crisis Health professionals/workforce industrial decarbonization Industrial strategy Industry
Infrastructure Investment Mayors Nuclear power Ports Private investment Regions/Cohesion Research
Startups Steel Transport Unemployment War Ursula von der Leyen European Commission France
Germany

This email alert has been sent for your exclusive use as a POLITICO Pro subscriber. Forwarding or reproducing the article without the express, written permission of POLITICO Pro is a violation of the POLITICO Pro license agreement.

This email was sent to shondo@iies.co.jp

[Update settings](#) | [Unsubscribe from this email](#) | [Unsubscribe from all emails](#)

POLITICO SRL · Rue de la Loi 62 · Brussels 1040 · Belgium